

Amid rising racial tensions at the time, Price and her family relocated to Chicago in 1927. She pursued further studies at the American Conservatory of Music and the Chicago Musical College. In 1928, her composition *At the Cotton Gin* was published by a major music publishing firm. By 1932, she had won several awards for her *Piano Sonata in E Minor* and her *Symphony in E Minor*, the latter premiering with the Chicago Symphony Orchestra the following year.

Price is celebrated as a pioneering Black composer of classical music alongside contemporaries William Grant Still (also from Arkansas) and William Dawson. Her arrangement of *My Soul's Been Anchored in de Lord* was famously performed by contralto Marian Anderson during her historic 1939 Lincoln Memorial concert.

In recent years, Price's music has been performed by orchestras across Europe and the United States, including the Arkansas Symphony Orchestra. In 2018, she was inducted into the Arkansas Women's Hall of Fame and the Arkansas Black Hall of Fame, and honored by the Arkansas State Music Teachers Association, which had denied her membership 100 years earlier.

Florence Price passed away in 1953. A Chicago elementary school was named in her honor. In 2009, during renovations of a summer home she once owned in Illinois, a trove of her manuscripts and documents was discovered. These materials were donated to the University of Arkansas, where additional papers are archived.

*Each November, the **National Federation of Music Clubs** observes American Music Month, during which the annual Parade of American Music focuses on programs featuring music by American composers.*

***The Hot Springs Music Connection** raises money to provide scholarships to students from Garland County who are pursuing music-related degrees in college. HSMC is affiliated with the National Federation of Music Clubs, which provides opportunities for musical study, performance, and appreciation to more than 90,000 senior, student, and junior members in 5,200 music-related clubs and organizations nationwide. It is chartered by the Congress of the United States and is the only music organization member of the United Nations.*

Dedicated to finding and fostering young musical talent, the NFMC conducts annual Junior Festivals with approximately 100,000 participants. It offers more than three quarters of a million dollars in state and national competitions, including four \$20,000 biennial Young Artist awards, and the \$20,000 Ellis Award for Duo-Pianists. The Young Artist and Ellis Duo Piano awards include two years of performance bookings.



HOT SPRINGS MUSIC CONNECTION

HER SOUND, HER STORY

MUSIC BY
AMERICAN WOMEN

2025-2026 Season

Westminster Presbyterian Church
November 9, 2025
3:00 p.m.

Her Sound, Her Story: Music by American Women

WelcomeDr. Tom Bolton, President

Program Introduction.....Sheree O’Rorke, Chair

Program

Varsha.....Reena Esmail

Dr. Nathan Groot, *viola*

Original Poetry.....Jolene Williams

“Wind of the Spirit”

“Autumn Dance”

Awaken the Dawn (Psalm 108:1-5).....Jolene Williams

Allison Scott, *soprano*

Jolene Williams, *piano*

VerdantBaylee Burton

Bailey Burson, *clarinet*

Kristen La Madrid, *piano*

The Music of Florence Price

AdorationFlorence Price, arr. George Lin

Shelley Martin, *flute*

Jolene Williams, *piano*

Fantasy in PurpleFlorence Price

Dr. Austin Motley, *trombone*

Kristen La Madrid, *piano*

ElfentanzFlorence Price

Kristen Bomberger, *violin*

Kristen La Madrid, *piano*

ResignationFlorence Price

Ruby Hill, *soprano*

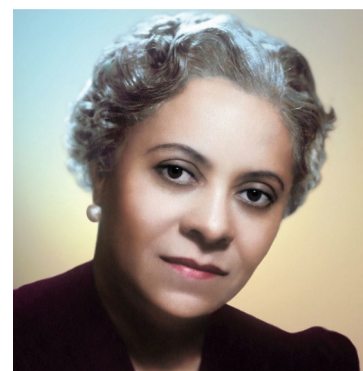
Kathie White, *alto*

Lowella Cherry, *piano*

SympathyFlorence Price

Ruby Hill, *soprano*

Lowella Cherry, *piano*



Florence Price (1887-1953)

Florence Smith Price was born in Little Rock, Arkansas, in 1887 and holds the distinction of being the first African-American woman composer to have a symphonic work performed by a major American orchestra. Her *Symphony in E Minor* was premiered by the Chicago Symphony Orchestra in 1933 and later featured at the Chicago World’s Fair.

Daughter of a dentist and a schoolteacher/

business-woman, Florence received early musical training from her mother. She published compositions while attending Capital Hill School in Little Rock, graduating as valedictorian in 1902 at the age of 14. She then studied at the prestigious New England Conservatory of Music in Boston, earning degrees in organ and piano pedagogy in 1906.

Price briefly taught music in Cotton Plant, Arkansas, before moving to North Little Rock to teach at Shorter College. In 1910, she became head of the music department at Clark University in Atlanta, a position she held until 1912. That year, she returned to Little Rock to marry attorney Thomas Jewell Price. There, she established a music studio, taught piano, and composed short piano pieces.